



Depth of Cultivation of Syllable VA

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The VA itself is compassion or compassionate consciousness and has two meanings:

1. In the *Avatamsaka sutra*, this syllable, this symbol means “Cause to dwell on the true mind, the selfless consciousness, the altruistic consciousness”. To dwell is to abide, to dwell is to stay; and everywhere, not only one place but any place, anytime, we can dwell, we can abide in that consciousness. The meaning of VA is compassion.
2. The second meaning of this VA comes from the *Shingon* tradition. And it means: “transcend all the words, cut off, leave behind”. You transcend all the words, the language, the expression, the culture and the knowledge. You simply transcend everything that is called expressions. This meaning was given by [Amoghavajra](#) (BuKong- Bất Không), the master who was the patriarch of the Shingon who came from India, and also reiterated by Kukai.

There are two things we have to remember when we visualize the syllable VA:

1. VA is ever-present. The body will eventually disappear, the body will die but the VA is ever-present. We don’t create the VA, we visualize it. The syllable VA is always there, compassion is ever-present, whether we can clearly visualize it or not.
2. We cultivate the syllable to emanate compassion, this is a huge concept. It’s so vastly important.

When we cultivate this emanation, do not expect to become Buddha or Arhat in this lifetime or in any future life. By cultivating according to the Hua Yen Buddhism, we don’t wait for the future to come: everything happens now, in every single moment, in this space and time. You can see that it is a great paradigm shift: we are not waiting anymore. Our attitude is to keep emanating the compassionate energy. As the syllable VA is ever present, we activate it. Let it coming out. We are confident that we have the Buddha nature, and we just open up and emanate compassion. It doesn’t mean that we are perfect. We still make mistakes. But that’s the ego, the self. So we have to work with the self and transform the self. However,



when we emanate the compassion, we transcend language, expression, culture, knowledge and we are the Buddha right at that moment. Try our best to make every time we sit is a moment that we are free.

The methodology used for the VA visualization is wonderful: with the syllable VA and the 4 other symbols, derivatives of the VA, the meditation steps are successive and harmonized:

1.  **VA: ever-present compassion.** First of all, we visualize the VA, the ever present compassion and affirm "I am Compassion".
2.  **VÀ: the practice of compassion.** Inhale to VA and emanate energy and we are thinking about turning that consciousness into energy. We unfold the loving and compassionate energy. That energy is coming out everywhere. We send this energy to our father, our mother, our family, people we love, people we hate, people we have entanglements.
3.  **VU: the practice of vows, of expansion, of transformation.** We direct our mind to open the heart of all beings in our web of affinity and make vows or commitment to realize that. This step requires us to engage in the world, care for others, support others, help others while expressing our compassion. As we do more and more, our heart of compassion expands. That is why it is called the practice of expansion. We extend our compassion to more people, and therefore our heart of compassion expands. In this process we are transforming ourselves and others.
4.  **VAM: the practice of being empty, the emptiness.** Empty or Emptiness can have two expressions (meanings):
 - a. One is to be empty of duality. This empty means no afflictions, no duality.
 - b. Practice to be empty is practice to be in the absolute emptiness, the "Sunyata".With the VAM, just become the consciousness, the energy and don't think about who it goes to. Forget about the body. With the thought "Let me become the wave", we have wake up that sense of being empty. We see that compassion and emptiness are just one.
5.  **VAH: the practice of consummation, the ultimate reality (non-dwelling Nirvana).** Nirvana doesn't mean a specific location that we have to reach. When we practice, we let the compassionate energy abide in every single living being's



consciousness, in the mind of all living beings. We become the energy of compassion, abide in everyone's heart. That is Nirvana. Whoever connects with us, we become the consciousness of compassion and we reside, abide and dwell in their heart. Isn't wonderful that now we don't need to have any special connection with anyone because we are in the heart of everyone. So that's the ultimate practice.

To summarize, these five syllables beginning with the VA is absolutely wonderful. It helps us to realize that everything we do, we are doing as part of a cycle:

- VA is ever-present,
- On the left, the syllable VÀ, we meditate and unfold energy,
- Come down, VU: we engage with the world, we make vows,
- And then with VAM, we make ourselves become empty. Empty and compassionate.
- And the last syllable VAH. Again we engage with the world and reside in everyone hearts and we make all the hearts and minds tend towards Bodhi, towards whatever we are enlightened to.

